robots.txt

Description	plain text document used by websites to communicate with web crawlers

The robots.txt file is a plain text document used by websites to **communicate** with web crawlers or search engine spiders.

This file provides instructions on which parts of the site can be crawled and which should be ignored. In other words, robots.txt offers guidance to search engines and other automated user agents on how to navigate through the site.

Here are some key points about the robots.txt file:

1. **File Content:** The robots.txt file is located in the root of the website and contains a series of directives for web crawlers.
2. Common directives include:
   - ***User-agent***: specifying the crawler to which the rule applies
   - **Disallow**: indicating pages or directories that should not be crawled

   For example, a common rule in the robots.txt file might be:

```
javascriptCopy code
User-agent: *
Disallow: /excluded-directory/
```

It is crucial to check the robots.txt file before performing web scraping operations on a site. Before collecting information from a web page, it is advisable to see if there are any specific restrictions listed in the site's robots.txt file.

📌 Respecting the rules set in a site's robots.txt is essential to maintain ethical behavior and respect the wishes of the site owner. Ignoring robots.txt directives can lead to legal consequences and harm the reputation of the web scraping script's author.

Web scraping developers can respect the robots.txt file by incorporating checks into their code. Before requesting or analyzing a page, they can verify if the page is allowed according to the directives in the site's robots.txt.

This helps avoid unauthorized requests and ensures compliance with the site's rules.

Termini di servizio (ToS)

Terms of Service (ToS), also known as Terms and Conditions, are legal documents that establish the rules and conditions under which users can use a particular service or website.

These documents outline the rights and responsibilities of both the user and the service provider. In the context of web scraping, ToS play a crucial role and are important for several reasons:

1. Legitimacy and Legal Compliance**:** Adhering to the Terms of Service is essential to ensure the legitimacy of web scraping activities. ToS define the rules set by the website owner, and disregarding them may lead to legal consequences. Violating ToS can constitute a breach of contract and could result in legal action.
2. **Usage Limitations:** ToS often outline limitations on the use of the website or its content. They may specify whether web scraping is allowed or prohibited and to what extent. Some sites may permit web scraping only for non-commercial purposes or may impose restrictions on the request rate to avoid server overloads.
3. **Intellectual Property:** ToS can clearly establish intellectual property rights over data and website content. Some sites may prohibit data extraction or reuse of content for commercial purposes without explicit consent from the site owner.
4. **Privacy Policies:** ToS may include information about the site's privacy policy, indicating how user personal data is handled and used. This is particularly relevant in the context of web scraping, as it is important to respect user privacy and not collect sensitive data without authorization.
5. **Terms Changes:** ToS may be subject to changes, and users are often required to abide by the latest versions. Periodically monitoring the ToS is important to ensure that web scraping activities comply with updated rules.